

Over the numerous builds of Windows that were released via the Insider program, one thing became clear, upgrades are still a pain on Windows. They take enormous amounts of time, and can require multiple reboots.

Microsoft needs to look at the platforms that have been doing constant upgrades for many years now. Linux distributions like Ubuntu and Fedora have been bringing new distribution releases every six months since many years now – over a decade in case of Ubuntu. Even more extreme examples are Arch, Gentoo, and OpenSUSE Tumbleweed which use a rolling release system where new updated applications and delivered almost daily.

Updates and upgrades on Linux rarely disrupt the work you are doing. Linux programmers and distributors and have made it a priority to ensure that critical applications can keep running while Linux updates, and suffer minimal downtime. The only thing that requires a reboot is a kernel upgrade, and even for that there are tools like kgraft, ksplice and kexec to update the kernel without a restart on servers.

Windows is at a disadvantage here. See on Linux it is possible to delete a file, even uninstall an entire application while it is still running. A deleted file can still be accessed by an application that has opened it. The result of this is that it's possible to replace an application with a newer version without needing to close it. If you want to start using the updated version, just close the application and start it again.

This is simply not how Windows is built. Windows updates require complex orchestration to pass over control from the old version to the new, and Microsoft really needs to make this work better and faster, because it's no longer an optional pain that people have to endure every 3 years if they decide to upgrade, it is now part of the Windows experience. 